Richard Bradley

Born around 1688, noted British botanist Richard Bradley gained patrons after writing a *Treatise of Succulent Plants* at the age of 22. With no university education, he was nonetheless elected a Fellow of the Royal Society and later became the first professor of botany at Cambridge.

Bradley's research interests were wide-ranging, including fungal spore germination and plant pollination. In some cases, Bradley was ahead of his time; he argued, for example, that infections were caused by tiny organisms, visible only with a microscope. His investigations into the productivity of rabbit warrens and fish lakes led to his theories about predator–prey relations. Bradley died in 1732.

Key works

1716–27 *The History of Succulent Plants*

1718 *New Improvements in Planting and Gardening*

1721 *A Philosophical Account of the Works of Nature*

See also: Predator–prey equations • Mutualisms • Keystone species • Optimal foraging theory • Animal ecology • The ecosystem • Trophic cascades • Ecological resilience